



IN MANMOHAN'S ABSENCE, PRESIDENT PATIL AND ANTONY PLAYED HOST TO THE KAZAKHSTAN PRESIDENT

Second in COMMAND

There is no constitutional provision for a deputy premier but intra-party feuds have catapulted many to the post



1 SARDAR VALLABHBHAI PATEL (CONGRESS)

Term of Office: August 1947 to December 1950

The Iron Man stayed No. 2 to Pandit Nehru despite their frequent skirmishes.

2 MORARJI DESAI (CONGRESS)

Term of Office: March 1967 to December 1969

Quit following tiff with Indira Gandhi over bank nationalisation. Later became prime minister.

3 CHAUDHARY CHARAN SINGH (JANATA PARTY)

Term of Office: July 1979 to October 1979

Was deputy in the first non-Congress regime. Later had the shortest stint as prime minister.

4 BABU JAGJIVAN RAM (JANATA PARTY)

Term of Office: October 1979 to December 1979

An able administrator, it was said of him that he was the best prime minister India never had.

5 YASHWANTRAO CHAVAN (JANATA PARTY)

Term of Office: December 1979 to January 1980

Had the shortest stint as the deputy prime minister, serving for less than a month.

6 CHAUDHARY DEVI LAL (JANATA DAL)

Term of Office: December 1989 to June 1991

He was elected prime minister in a drama played out in Central Hall, but settled for the No. 2 slot.

7 L. K. ADVANI (BJP)

Term of Office: June 2002 to May 2004

A personal dream was met halfway when he was made deputy PM, a post held by his icon Patel.

8 GULZARI LAL NANDA (CONGRESS)

Terms of Office: May 1964 and January 1966

Served two fortnight-long stints as interim prime minister following deaths of Nehru and Shastri.

ATTEMPTS IN THE PAST TO PUT A HIERARCHY IN PLACE HAVE FAILED AS GOVERNMENTS ADMITTED IN COURT THAT ALL MINISTERS ARE EQUAL

Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel became the first deputy prime minister, even before the Constitution of India was framed, as a part of the Congress party's original power struggle. Morarji Desai was the next to be elevated, in 1967, in an oblique effort to diminish his rant and rave against Indira Gandhi. (see box) The last one to become deputy prime minister was L.K. Advani, nothing more than a affirmation from prime minister A.B.

Vajpayee that the man who was his No. 2 in BJP held the same position in the government too.

Beyond protocol hair pulling, the crisis has more implications on the government's coherent functioning. Ad hocism is dangerous when the country is facing security threats and economic crisis. Ensuring a constitutional provision for a deputy prime minister will put in place a clear chain of command. *by Shafi Rahman*